Personal Growth Leads The Way

BlueStars ADMISSIONS CONSULTING

College Planning Foundations Workbook

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Introduction

***Be yourself; everyone else is already taken.* - Oscar Wilde**

You won't believe it, but high school goes by really fast! The next thing you know, you're a stressed-out senior trying to figure out whether you like bioinformatics or bioengineering, which schools might be best for the plan you haven't yet defined, and how to write a personal essay without a clear vision of your goals and aspirations. Overwhelming!

But there's another way – one in which you start early, set foundations, and tackle things step-by-step. We know that planning for college while also dealing with the challenges of high school is a big job. Most teens need help with it. That's why we created these worksheets for you.



Avoid becoming that stressed-out senior! To do so, we recommend that you start the process of exploring and organizing as early as possible (ideally in 9th grade). Knowledge about your future will become your personal superpower.

Try to take an hour or two a week to focus on your unique college path. Doing a little bit over a longer period of time will make it all feel *so much less stressful*. Consider it a form of teen self-care!

How can you present your best self to colleges so that admitting you is a no-brainer? Start with Step 1.

Step 1: An Exercise in Getting Grounded

What do top colleges look for? Hint: It's not "being a hard worker." This exercise will introduce you to seven key personality traits top schools consider most important. You probably already possess some (if not all) of them!

Step 2: Writing a Personal Essay

If you learn how to write a personal narrative ahead of time – in ninth or tenth grade – you'll find yourself feeling very comfortable expressing yourself in your college applications. By the

time you finish this step-by-step worksheet on the "hero's journey," you'll have drafted your first personal essay. It's actually easier than you think!

Step 3: An Exercise in Branching Out and Exploring Your Interests

Contrary to popular belief, colleges don't look for well-rounded students. Instead, they want to create a well-rounded class. This means that colleges are less interested in cookie-cutter applicants (sport, instrument, some volunteering) than students with 3-4 well-defined interests. This worksheet will help you think "outside the box" about your unique interests and activities.

Step 4: A Goal-Setting Exercise to Help You Activate Your Interests

Now that you've defined your interests, how do you narrow them down to just a few and then make cool plans connected to them? How do you include new things into your already busy schedule? Once you see your life in terms of concrete goals, you will feel much more calm and organized. Try it and see!

Step 5: A Timeline to Help You Put It All Together

Colleges like students who get things done. How can you meet all (or most – no one is perfect!) of the goals you've set up for yourself? Just like an architect or engineer, you've got to map things out in advance. This monthly timeline will snap things into place for you!

Extra Resources For You!

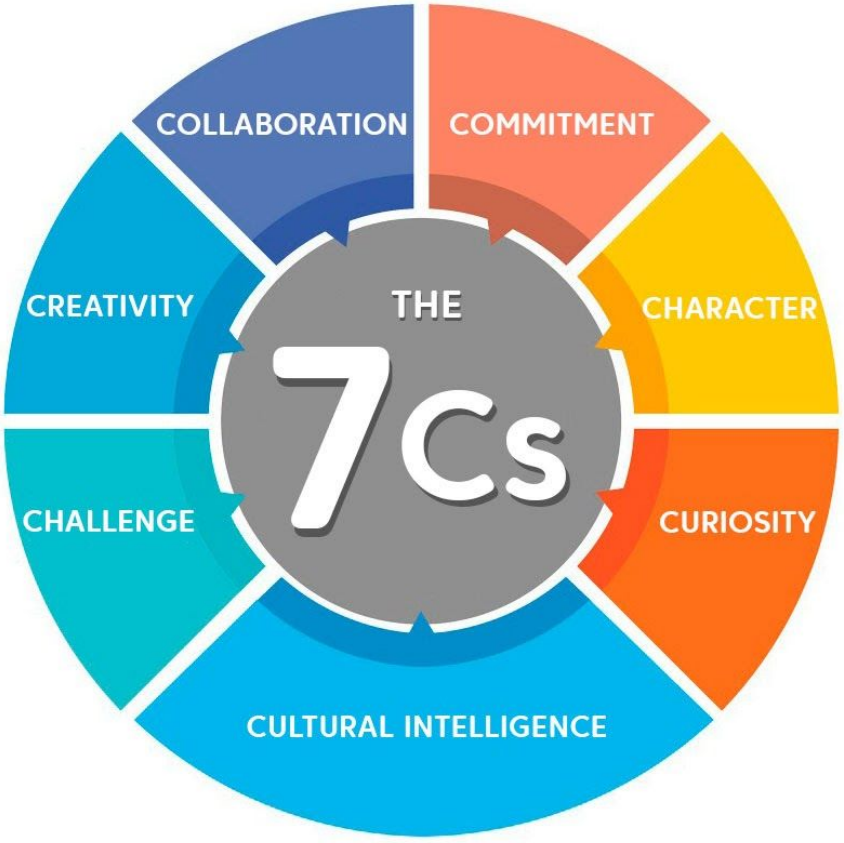
How can you follow up on all the plans you've mapped out in this workbook? To give you extra support, we've gathered our favorite resources in time-management, career and interest exploration, mindfulness, and college life. We hope they help make your college planning journey a time of great personal growth.

Step 1: Identifying Key Personality Traits Important to Top Colleges

When we ask students what personality traits they think colleges care about, they pretty much always give the same wrong answer: being hardworking. Wrong, wrong, wrong! But why?

Well, first of all, if everyone says the same thing about themselves – that they are hardworking – no applicant stands out. Second, colleges already expect applicants to be hardworking.

Colleges look for additional personality traits when making selections. Which ones?



We've located seven key personality traits – the 7Cs – to give you concrete guidance.

Here's the good news before you even get started: you probably already possess some of the traits top schools look for! Hopefully, this first step in your college planning journey will feel reassuring for you.

Are you ready? **Make notes in each section below on how you can demonstrate each trait.** Take a deep breath and… let's get started!

Your Seven Key Traits

Character: Since they are creating a community when selecting applicants, colleges seek students with a generous, ethical character. How can you show your generous character? Perhaps you've volunteered steadily for the same homeless shelter all four years of high school, as one of our students did, or teach piano to a child on the autism spectrum. Or maybe, you make all of your gifts by hand. The possibilities are endless, and everyone has their own unique way of showing their generosity. *Can you think of instances where your generous, ethical character led the way?*

Take notes here!

Collaboration: Because the modern work world is all about collaborating in teams, **colleges want to know if you can "play well with others."** While they are interested in the academic skills you bring, colleges also want to know how you relate to your peers in a professional setting. You might think colleges look for leadership skills. They do. But they're most interested in leaders who bring people together. *Think of a few examples that showcase how well you work with others.* Participation in robotics, a school club, a group project, or a job might provide examples for you. Feel free to think outside of the box, however!

Take notes here!

Creativity: Colleges like students who see things in a new way. This does not mean that you need to be an artsy student. It means starting something that hasn't been done before. **Think about your creativity in terms of "taking initiative."** Maybe you realized your school needed an environmental club, so you started one, or that a free medical clinic in your neighborhood could use donations of equipment, so you rounded some up. Maybe you created an inspirational mural at a bus stop in your town, or a new dish in the family kitchen. When you think about examples of your creativity and initiative, think widely and broadly. *What examples do you have of things you've started?*

Take notes here!



Challenge: While it may not always feel good in the moment, some of your greatest challenges might turn out to be your admissions strengths! **More than anything, colleges want to know how you've changed or grown during your high school years.** One of our favorite examples in this category is the story of the student who wrote her Common Application essay about being a band camp team captain and leading her team to utter defeat. She was crushed and humiliated. But she learned valuable lessons from the setback and became a stronger person as a result. She was also accepted to Stanford!

Yes, you can "fail," even write your main essay about it, and land at a premier school. Of course, this student wrote about what she learned from this setback, not just about the setback. Consider times that you've learned from a setback or overcome a challenge.

Take notes here!

Curiosity: Colleges care about where students' minds roam, and how they roam (most especially on their own time, outside the classroom or organized extracurriculars). They consider reading books, viewing informational videos, listening to podcasts, querying on Reddit, or tinkering with an Arduino in the garage vital for personal development. **Do you take things at face value, or do you dig deeper and investigate for yourself?** We've met so many students who proclaim their love of artificial intelligence or virtual reality but have nothing to say about how these technologies can impact society, good and bad. These students experience difficulty with interviews and often do not get into their dream schools. *What are you curious about? Where and how do you pursue what you're curious about?*

Take notes here!

Commitment: It's one thing to say you're interested in artificial intelligence, animal conservation, or finding a cure for Alzheimer's. It's another to show your interest through active involvement over time. Take the Berkeley grad who, while still in high school, ran an art studio for kids on weekends in her garage, or the Arizona State Honors admit who interned at a physical therapy office, or the STEM student who organized a team for a local tech challenge: **each student was able to prove their dedication through concrete activity.** *Thinking through your activities, which ones match up with your interests?* Which ones mean the most to you or say the most about you? Write those down in your key traits diagram!

Take notes here!

Cultural Intelligence! What kinds of experiences do you have with people who differ from you in terms of socioeconomic status, cultural experience, regional background, or religious influence? Are you someone who creates or works within groups of people from diverse backgrounds? Are you a bridge builder? **In our multicultural, interconnected society, colleges want to see that you are comfortable with personal or cultural differences** and can move among varying social groups in a harmonious way. *Can you think of examples in which you experienced or brought about diversity?*

Take notes here!

Concluding thoughts….

Now that you've made notes in each section of your key traits diagram, CONGRATULATIONS! **You made it through a very important first step – a personal traits inventory.** This is not an easy exercise. So take a moment to pat yourself on the back for getting to this milestone. Deep breath. Inhale, exhale. A few times.

At this point, you are probably feeling affirmed and maybe even a little calm about the examples you've already written down. You should! That's because they show you the strengths you already bring to colleges. You are probably also feeling nervous about the examples you couldn't come up with. That's okay.

Part of becoming a young adult is feeling confident about what you already have to offer while also working on the areas that need strengthening. It's best not to be too positive (overly confident) or too negative (self-critical) about your traits.

This new framework can also help you choose future activities. Will a certain activity bring out one (or some) of the Seven Key Personality Traits? If yes, then it might be a good choice.

Even better, **the Seven Key Personality Traits can help you decide between activities if you don't have time for all of them.** Soccer or bio research? Extra class or volunteer? Once you match these activities with traits, the decision might be more obvious than you think!

Step 2: Your First Hero's Journey Narrative

Our goal at Blue Stars is to help teens feel less scared of the college admissions essay. **Believe it or not, telling your story is actually easier than you think!** You just need to learn how to do it.

If you practice writing a personal narrative ahead of time – in ninth or tenth grade – you'll find yourself feeling very comfortable expressing yourself in your college essays.



You will be like our former student and recent applicant, Susan, whose classmates wondered why she wasn't more stressed in the fall of her senior year. Susan felt confident and calm while writing because she'd practiced creating personal narratives ahead of time.

Then there's the example of Matt. Early on in high school, Matt learned how to write about himself for internship, job, and summer program applications. He got some great opportunities! Then when it came time to apply for college, he was a pro! Because Matt spent a few years writing personal essays, he became more relaxed about it and could reveal his true personality in his writing.

If you give yourself time to learn how to write a personal narrative, the true you will shine through. But if you wait until college application time, your story will probably feel stiff and unnatural, both to you and your reader. That's because it's not really possible to learn a new process for the first time and be a pro at it.

So let's get some practice.

This worksheet will help you transform your free-write anecdote on one of the 7 Key Traits into your first personal narrative! More specifically, it will guide you through writing a Hero's Journey. All you have to do is follow the steps.....

What is the The Hero's Journey? It's a story about breaking through some sort of challenge. Think about your favorite superhero movie. I bet your movie fits into this pattern:

- The movie starts with your hero doing just fine.
- Then something happens that causes a problem or disruption.
- Your hero spends most of the movie dealing with the problem or disruption: there's a push and pull between positive and negative events, and you're not 100% sure if the hero will triumph; you're in suspense!
- Your hero triumphs! He or she also learns valuable lessons along the way.
- Your hero shares what he or she has learned (the movie might not have this part, but let's imagine it does!).

Maybe you don't feel like a superhero. That's okay! You don't have to be famous or do something extreme like save polar bears from extinction to be a hero. Everyone faces challenges, and that's what makes every person heroic. So let's get started!

Step 1: Read through the Steps 2-5, and then go to Step 2.



Step 2: Look back at your two anecdotes from the 7 Key Traits exercise, and pick the anecdote you think works best for your first hero's journey essay. Write down a few key words about information or insights or feelings you want to be sure to include. This will help you focus your thoughts. (Once you've completed your draft, you might want to check back here to make sure you got it all in.)

Jot down keywords here!

Step 3: Draft Your Opening Paragraph. This is the part where you're "doing just fine." The soccer game, or study session, or summer band camp is rolling along as planned, and then…..(your opening ends right before the problem or disruption).

To draft your opening paragraph, you'll need to describe a scene. Good scenes include vivid detail of the who, what, when, where, and how. If you're writing about summer band camp, for example, your reader will want to know things like:

- Who are the participants or "characters"?
- What is the purpose of the activity?
- What kinds of things are the characters doing?
- When did the camp take place? Day or night? For how long? How many months or years ago?
- What is the camp's location? Is it indoors or outdoors? What does the location look like? How does it feel? Is it hot or cold? Dim or well-lit?
- How were things supposed to happen (before the problem or disruption shows up)?
- If band camp were a movie, what would it look like?
- Are there any other sensory details that would make this scene memorable? Vivid detail comes when you write about sensory impressions of the scene.

Feel free to draft your opening in a way that feels easy and simple. Don't worry about "being a good writer." That will come with revisions! For now, all you need to do is write out the details of the scene in the text box below.

Tip! Answer each of the questions above separately in separate bullet points. Then, once you've brainstormed each point, create a short paragraph connecting the most important pieces of information in a paragraph of 3-5 sentences. You can do both of these things in the text box below.

Brainstorm and draft here!

Important note: Don't worry about transitions between paragraphs. That's for revision! Focus just on each separate writing activity. It will eventually come together. Trust in the process :)



Step 4: Draft Your Middle Paragraph.

Now is the time for action and suspense! You will start this paragraph by talking about the challenge you faced. What set off the change in events? Write about that first.

Let's go back to the band camp example, a real example from Ellie, a Blue Stars student who wound up attending Stanford and wrote her Common

Application essay about leading her team to fourth place and total defeat! Crushing. Disappointing. Not what she'd intended or expected. Most of her essay was about this stuff. The rest was about how she handled the defeat over the next six months.

So now it's your turn to plunge into the play-by-play of the gritty action in your hero's journey! Here are some substeps:

- First state what happened (for example, "Much to my horror, I lost band camp for my team!")
- Next write about how it happened. What was the chain of events that led to this outcome? Tell the backstory.
- How did you react to what happened? Maybe you reacted in more than one way. Maybe your reaction changed over time. Write about all of your reactions.

Try for about 10-15 sentences in the text box below, or about 250 words. Don't worry if it's messy. Your goal here is to make sure you've included every detail in your play-by-play. You'll clean things up later!

Draft your middle paragraph here!

Tip: You'll become a better writer faster if you write more during the drafting stage, rather than some minimal amount. It's actually easier to cut content than generate new details once you start to care about the quality of your writing at a later stage in the revision process. So write as much as you can at this early stage, more than 15 sentences if you'd like. Once you have a lot of content, you might find it fun to sort through, organize, and even play with your raw material. I promise!

Step 5: Draft Your Concluding Paragraph. This is where you tie things together and communicate all the ways you benefited from the challenge you hadn't expected. In our band camp example, after feeling embarrassment and disappointment, Ellie eventually realized that there are different styles of leadership and that she didn't have to be good at every single one of them. So what if she wasn't great at band camp captain? That was one week! She happened to be excellent at leading others as a music and math coach, helping individuals achieve their personal excellence. By the end of the essay, she was no longer upset. In fact, she'd discovered something new and cool about herself.

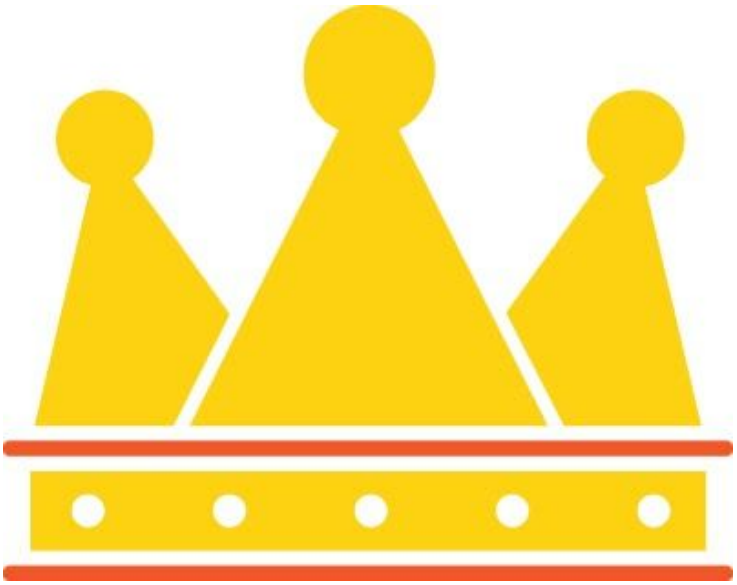
What are your takeaways from the situation you describe in the middle paragraph? First, write out a bulleted list. Write the longest list you can. Then, pick the most important points and

write a paragraph of 2-4 sentences. Write in a way that feels natural and easy for you. There is no one right way!

Draft your conclusion here!

CONGRATULATIONS! You've now drafted the main components of your first personal narrative. Of course, it's still sort of a mess (as it should be!), but a huge part of the hard work is over.

Next Steps... If you feel comfortable revising your own drafts, start thinking about how to link your paragraphs together into one narrative flow and then work on the internal coherence of each of your paragraphs. You might find that you'll need to break up your middle paragraph into a few paragraphs.



If you're not sure how to proceed, find an adult you trust to guide you. If you show that person your completed worksheet, I bet you'll get lots of help. Adults love to assist teens who show initiative!

Whether you revise your work by yourself, with a group of peers, or with someone more experienced in writing, this rubric provides you with a concrete framework for next steps. Good luck and happy writing!

Essay Revision Rubric

	Excellent	Good	Really Needs Work
Ideas & Content	The essay is clear, focused, and specific. The writing is packed with detail.	The essay has some really good parts, but it could use more supporting details.	It sounds like the writer is still trying to figure out what to say.
Organization	The essay has a clear and compelling direction. The reader wants to find out what is coming next.	The order makes sense most of the time. The reader can follow it pretty well.	The ideas and paragraphs are jumbled and hard for the reader to understand.
Sentence Fluency	The sentences are clear and there is variety in length and how they start.	Most of the sentences are clear but there are a few choppy ones as well. Also, a number of sentences start in the same manner.	There are too many unnecessary words and the sentence style is rarely changed.
Word Choice	The words in the essay are clear, visual, and accurate. Some of the words and phrases are so vivid that the reader will not forget them.	The words get the message across but don't capture the reader's imagination.	There are too many clichés or vague terms. The word choice needs to be more specific.
Voice	The essay is individual and powerful. The writing has lots of personality. It sounds different from how everyone else writes.	The essay shows some of the writer's personality but the reader isn't laughing, crying, or pounding on the table.	The essay tells more than shows. It is hard to identify the writer's personality.
Conventions	The essay is mostly correct. Capitals, punctuation, spelling, and grammar usage is almost perfectly correct.	Some mistakes that need to be corrected. A few grammar issues make the reader stumble.	There are a number of grammar, spelling, and punctuation mistakes.

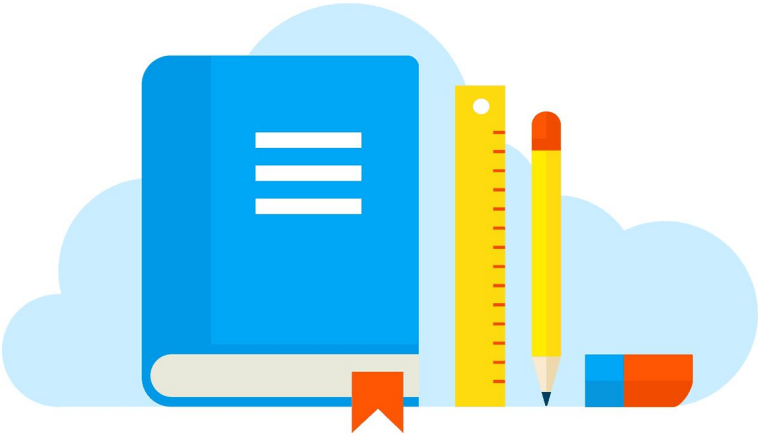
Step 3: Exploring Skills and Interests

Do you know exactly what you want to do "when you grow up?"

If your answer is somewhere between "Uh, maybe?" and "No idea," don't worry! You are not alone. Most teens are unsure about their future path. It is normal and natural for someone your age.

Still, it's annoying when everyone around you seems to think you should have it all planned out. Maybe you even feel impatient with yourself. That, too, is normal and natural. You are responding to societal expectations in a reasonable way.

Most people aren't born knowing what they want to do, but there are ways to figure it out.



This exercise will help you figure out your direction, one that genuinely comes from *your* actual interests and who *you* really are. When you define your interests "from the inside out" – from the things you really like and are good at – chances are you'll be happier at what you do, more committed to it, and better at it.

Many people try to figure out what they want to do "from the outside in." They make choices to please others around them, or they don't know about other options. As a teen, you might find yourself thinking in terms of what the adults around you want you to do, or what other kids are focusing on.

You also might not know about careers beyond the usual list of suspects: engineer, doctor, businessperson. There are LOTS MORE jobs than those! It's just that no one ever tells you about them. Maybe one you've never even thought of might be perfect for you. Makes sense, right? So how do you go about figuring out what *you* want to do?

We have a helpful tool: The Skills and Interests Grid!



Using the grid at the end of this section, you can **match up what you are good at with what you are interested in** so you can brainstorm jobs, extracurriculars, or community service activities.

This tool will help you define activities for your high school years in a creative and fun way. Once you've located things you like and are good at, you can then get involved in activities connected to them. And once you've become active, you'll have already started your unique path to college! So let's do the beginning work of *discovery and definition*...

Step 1. Think of 10 things that you're good at, and write them down in a list. It does not matter if you like these things. You just have to be good at them.

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.
6.
7.
8.
9.

10.

How do you figure out what you are good at?

Here are a series of questions you can think about and answer to figure this out:

- Up to this point, what have been your favorite classes in school? List them specifically (don't just say "math," say "geometry"). Why have these been your favorites? What skills do those classes use (creativity, hard work, initiative, writing)?
- What do you like to do for fun? Why? Be specific! Do you like any of them because you're good at them? You can use those.
- List the organized clubs or formal activities -- Boy Scouts, youth orchestra, etc. -- you belong to. Which are your favorites and why? What skills and abilities do these use? These can be things you're good at.
- Have you won any awards or competitions in any of your classes or for any of your activities? List them and explain what they were for -- they might be for things you're good at.

Step 2: Now from this list of 10 things you're good at, pick 5 of those things you really like doing. If you're having a hard time distinguishing which things you like and which you don't like, then rank the items from 1 to 10 in order of interest and list the top 5 here:

1.

2.

3.

4.

5.

Step 3: Write these 5 things down across the top of the Skills and Interests Grid.

Step 4: Write a list of things you're interested in. (These things need to be **different** from the first list you entered, and they don't have to be anything you've ever actually done -- just topics or activities you think you find interesting.)

1.
2.
3.
4.
5.

How do you come up with this list?

- Are there any other hobbies or interests you wish you had more time to pursue? What are they? Be specific.
- If you had 24 hours to do anything you wanted, what would you do? These don't have to be interests you've ever actually pursued. They can also be things you do pursue unofficially -- as hobbies, on your own, when they're not assigned in school.
- What do you like spending your time on even if and when no one tells you you should? Put those down.

Step 5: Add your list of 5 interests down the left side of the grid.

Step 6 (it's a big one): In each box at the intersection of a row and column, brainstorm a job or activity that involves those two things. For example, if the top of your column says "Basketball" and the intersecting row says "Videogames" you could write "Designing a basketball video game" in that box.

"Yeah, but no one actually does that for a living... I mean, that's not a 'real' job...." They don't? Here's Wikipedia's List of Basketball Video games. You don't think someone's getting paid for designing these? They sure are!

Helpful hint: You don't have to do the whole grid all at once! Feel free to fill in the grid in more than one sitting. You can also create a quick system and work on, say, one cell a day. Think of it like a puzzle or scavenger hunt.

Pro Tip: If you have a hard time coming up with ideas for some of the cells, start off by asking some people you know for help. Perhaps there are adults in your world who can converse with you about different ideas. Or you can share a blank copy with your friends and help one another with ideas. Or ask your parents for their suggestions.

Skills & Interests Grid Examples

	1. Problem Solving	2. Socializing	3. Communication	4.Competition/ Investigating	5. Teaching?
1. Business	Chief Innovation Officer	Salesman/manager	Human Resource Officer or Manager	Sales/public relations	Business Teacher
2. Entrepreneurship	Company that makes someone's life easier	Internet based social platform (Online penpal)	Pitching to investors, marketing, branding, building partnerships	Entrepreneur (high ambition)	Entrepreneur Teacher
3. Biology	Marine Biology/Forensic Science	Behavioral economics	Health Communication specialist	Biologist	Bio Teacher
4. Medicine	Medical Scientist	Biotech or pharmaceutical sales	Biotech or pharmaceutical sales	Medical Scientist	Also sales…
5. Psychology	Research Psychologist	Psychologist	Mental Health/Child Psychologist	Psychologist	Psychology professor

	1. Coding	2. Math	3. Biology	4. Music	5. Basketball	6. Golf
1. Electronics	Programmer Robotics Building something using Arduino	Financial engineering Educational technology to teach math	Environmental test equipment Robotic limbs Pacemakers/medical equipment	Electronic synthesizers Digital composing Making instruments	Electronics that help certain basketball skills	Electronics that help certain golf skills
2. Digital Photography	Visual search engines -- medical/consumer	AI digital photography algorithms	Wildlife photography	Make posters promoting a musical event	Basketball photographer	Golf photographer
3. Video Games	Code video games	Help children learn math with interactive game	Population/Ecosystem simulations	Guitar game that helps with guitar skills	Design a basketball video game	Mini golf video game
4. Fantasy / Fiction	Code an archery shooting game	Math problem solving escape room	Exobio/Astrobio Film: Avatar, Jurassic Park Design Disney or theme park exhibits	Write music for animated fiction movie	Develop playable media that encourages people to play basketball	Fantasy fiction video game with a golf hero Design mini-golf course
5. Entrepreneurship	Hackathons Starting a software company	Math educational software company Self-paced digital math curriculum	Founding an environmental nonprofit	Youtube channel playing the guitar	Start a nonprofit that uses basketball to teach leadership/team skills	Use golf to help others learn how to control their minds/develop focus and mental discipline

Your Skills & Interests Grid

Step 4: Goal-Setting to Help Activate Your Interests

In Step 1, you gained a picture of the qualities top colleges look for, and you conducted a self-evaluation of your qualities. You set some personal foundations. In Step 3, you brainstormed unique activities that combine your interests and skills. You started to expand out beyond your immediate world and knowledge base. This is already great progress!

Now it is time to get organized. But how to start? Well, you can't go anywhere until you know where you're going. You need a destination, a landing point, right?



That's what goals are for – to give you landing points and help you direct your energy. Once you set your goals for, say, the semester or the summer, you'll gain a better picture of your life during that time frame. And once you have a clear picture, you'll know what to do!

Before you start, you need a **quick lesson about a special way of writing your goals** – a way that will get you instantly organized.

Look at the two different versions below:

Raise my grades	Raise my grade in Biology from a B to an A
Study harder	Add an extra half hour of Bio review 3x/week
Volunteer more	Find 3 new organizations of interest and apply

What do you notice about the items in the left column? They are vague and provide no landing point. What do you notice about the items on the right? They pretty much give you a blueprint for action. You're already organized!

These are called SMART goals. In case you are wondering, SMART stands for: Specific, Measurable, Actionable, Realistic, and Time-bound.

S	**Specific**	• What is the concrete expected result? • Describe the destination rather than the means of reaching it
M	**Measurable**	• How will I measure success? • What level of performance is expected? • Are there milestones that should be achieved along the way?
A	**Actionable**	• How will I accomplish this goal? • Does this goal stretch me?
R	**Realistic**	• Can I expect to achieve this goal as stated with the support I can realistically expect?
T	**Time-bound**	• Define completion dates

A SMART goal is like a **translation machine** taking a wish of yours on one end and transforming it into an actionable item on the other. How cool is that? So let's take one of the examples above and put it through the SMART test.

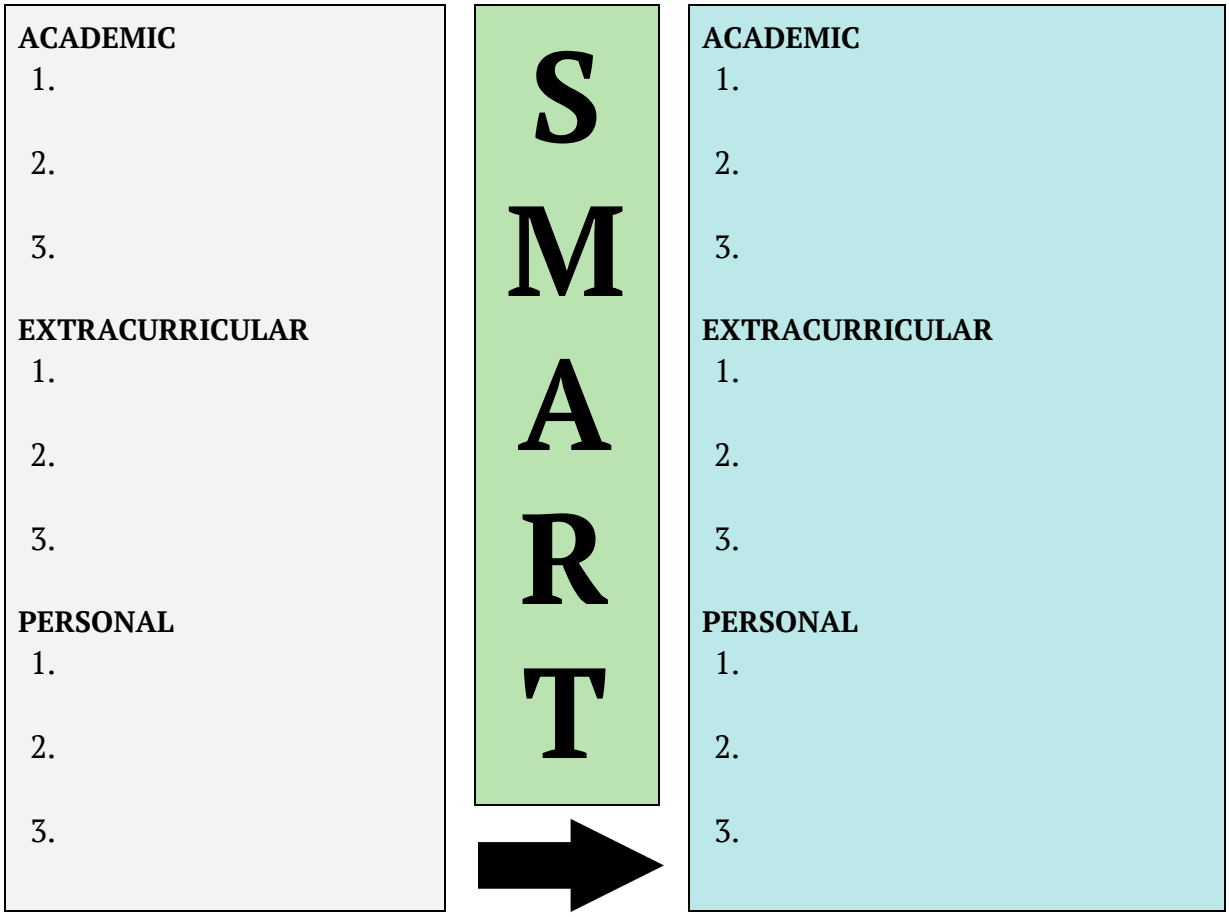


Let's say you want to raise your grade from a B to an A in Biology. Is this goal:

Specific? Yes, because you list two specific grades. If you have numerical grades and want to get more specific (like going from an 87 to 92, that's also an option).
Measurable? Yes, because you're dealing with specific grades.
Actionable? Let's assume you have the time for extra study time, so yes.
Realistic? Let's assume you have the aptitude for this subject and you're not just dreaming about what you can do, so yes.
Time-bound? Yes, since this goal is for a particular semester.

So how can you start setting goals for yourself?

Step 1: Write a first draft of your goals in a way that feels natural to you according to the categories below.
Step 2: Put your goals through the SMART translation machine to get your blueprint.



Goal-setting is **one of two** important steps in getting organized. When you set goals, you translate your wishes or intentions into actionable items.

Well, now that you have all of these awesome goals, how do you know if you can do it all? Are you taking on too much? Or too little? You won't know until you put all of your goals into a timeline. Once you map out your goals, you'll be ready to activate your plan! **In the next step we will see what timelining looks like, and how it can help you.**

Here's an example of SMART goals to help guide you!

Fall Semester Goals

ACADEMIC

1. 1400 on SAT, December sitting
2. Finish semester with 4.0 GPA unweighted
3. Work to improve essay score to 6-7
4. Study notes each night for at least 30 minutes to prevent procrastination for upcoming test and finals
    a. Precalc: practice extra equations for 15-20 minutes a day
    b. Chem: Review elements and notes from class each night for at least 15 minutes

EXTRACURRICULAR

1. Pass practical piano exam this October
2. Continue to participate as a GM - raise $1,000 from fundraisers
3. Finish at least 5 hours of volunteer work each month

PERSONAL

1. Drink all of my water from my 32oz water bottle for hydration
2. Check up on goals at least twice each week to ensure I am following through with them
3. Refrain from texting to concentrate on studying
4. Find time to relax each week to reduce stress

PRE-PROFESSIONAL

1. Continue GWC every Thursday at the library to learn more about computer science
2. Visit at least one college during winter break
3. Do 1-2 Career Girls exercises

DAILY

1. Get at least 7-8 hours of sleep every night
2. Keep up with news each day
3. Review daily planner every afternoon to become more organized and to have better time management
4. Get up at 6:30 to ensure that I won't be tardy at school

Step 5: Your College Prep Timeline

Colleges like students who get things done. How can you meet all (or most – no one is perfect!) of the goals you've set up for yourself? Just like an architect or engineer, you've got to map it all out in advance. This monthly timeline will help you map out your monthly milestones so that **your plans snap into place for you!**



Step 1: Take one of the goals you set for yourself. Now think about the smaller steps needed to achieve it. If your goal is to raise your grade, you'll want to write down midterms and finals on your timeline. If your goal is to make the soccer team, jot down when tryouts take place.

Step 2: Write down each step toward your goals in the appropriate year and month of your college prep timeline.

Step 3: Take a step back and look at the items in each month. Then ask yourself: Can I handle all of the items? Do I need to cut back? Do I actually have more time than I realized, now that I've mapped out essential milestones? Each student is unique and can handle a different load of activities, so try to be honest with yourself about what you can handle.

Step 5: Print your timeline out (maybe even blow it up poster size!) so that you have a daily reminder of your main milestones.

Step 6: Activate! We recommend getting enough sleep (8-9 hours) and managing social media so that you can stay on track. See our time-management and mindfulness tools on the resource page for more assistance.

Here's a helpful example from a student, and at the end of this section a complete outline of suggested activities for each year!

Your College Prep Timeline

Freshman Year - Fall

Month	Task
August-September	• • • •
October	• • • •
November	• • • •
December	• • • •

Freshman Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• • • •
February	• • • •
March	• • • •

April	• • • •
May	• • • •

Freshman/Sophomore Year - Summer

Month	Task
June	• • • •
July	• • • •

Sophomore Year - Fall

Month	Task
August	• • • •
September	• • • •
October	• • • •
November	•

	• • •
December	• • • •

Sophomore Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• • • •
February	• • • •
March	• • • •
April	• • • •
May	• • • •

Sophomore/Junior Year - Summer

Month	Task
June	• • •

	•
July	• • • •

Junior Year - Fall

Month	Task
August	• • • •
September	• • • •
October	• • • •
November	• • • •
December	• • • •

Junior Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• • • •

February	• • • •
March	• • • •
April	• • • •
May	• • • •

Junior/Senior Year - Summer

Month	Task
June	• • • •
July	• • • •

Senior Year - Fall

Month	Task
August	• • • •
September	• •

	• •
October	• • • •
November	• • • •
December	• • • •

Senior Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• • • •
February	• • • •
March	• • • •
April	• • • •
May	• • •

	•

Suggested College Prep Timeline

Freshman Year - Fall

Month	Task
August-September	• Start high school! Set up a time-management system for the semester. • Set up goals for the semester and map them out on a timeline • Check out school clubs and explore 3-4 you might be interested in • Fill out the Skills/Interest Worksheet to define some key interests
October	• Evaluate your time-management system and goals. Any changes needed for greater success? • Find ways to get to know your teachers; you never know when you'll need a recommendation letter • Become active in school activities; colleges love involved students! • Find a volunteering activity you can dedicate yourself to over time (See "Committed" under 6Cs)
November	• Get plenty of sleep (8-9 hours) so you can gear up for the second half of the semester • Maintain activities (or cut back temporarily if you need to keep your grades up); stick to priorities! • Begin thinking about summer plans (academic program, job, volunteer, science/art project?)
December	• Create study plan for finals; revise time-management system for finals prep • Maintain healthy sleep schedule to stay focused on academics • Begin applying to summer programs • Evaluate extracurricular involvement; any adjustments needed for next semester? • Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over break

Freshman Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• With lessons learned from the fall, create a new time-management plan • Set goals for the semester and summer • Stay focused on classes so you don't fall behind at the beginning of the semester • Start to think about summer volunteering, interning, or employment
February	• Increase your extracurricular involvement in current clubs with eye to leadership in a few • Keep up with your volunteering or independent projects (like math or writing competitions) • Select your classes for sophomore year • Complete summer program applications, if applying
March	• Keep up with your classes! Review time-management and goals! • Explore a few careers connected to your Skills-Interests Worksheet • Apply for summer volunteering, internship, or job opportunities
April	• Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over spring break

	• Create time for extra study on subjects that need reinforcement in preparation for finals • Stay organized, cutting back on some activities if you are feeling overloaded
May	• Create a study plan for finals and reorganize time-management for maximum success • Finalize those summer plans! • Try for an officer position in a club for sophomore year; or make plans to start a club (or both) • Revisit your goals, make adjustments, and stay focused to finish the semester strong

Freshman/Sophomore Year - Summer

Month	Task
Summer	• Activate your interests through an academic program, volunteer opportunity, or job • Keep up with assigned summer reading for sophomore year • Expand your mind through critical reading, viewing, or listening • Explore some careers through informational interviews, job shadowing, or web research • Keep up with your local volunteering • Save time for fun and relaxation! • Record your summer experiences in a journal; this might be handy for future applications! • Write a first draft of your resume if you haven't yet done so

Sophomore Year - Fall

Month	Task
August	• With renewed energy, define your goals for sophomore semester and then timeline milestones • Think about which extracurriculars will define you best. Try something new or stick with same? • Create your time-management and social media plan • Think about how you can define yourself outside of school or typical extracurricular activities • Research competitions if this is of interest to you
September	• If you are interested in a diagnostic score, take the PSAT • Keep up with your classes, noticing the increased demands of sophomore year • Get active in your chosen clubs or other extracurriculars • Start thinking about an independent project; what can you do to show your unique passions?
October	• Pay attention to sleep and wellness as the semester kicks into full swing • Maintain good relations with your teachers; get to know them • Keep up grades • Maintain extracurricular involvement • Start researching summer programs that build on last summer or introduce something different
November	• Get plenty of sleep (8-9 hours) so you can gear up for finals preparation • Maintain activities (or cut back temporarily if you need to keep your grades up); stick to priorities!

	• Begin thinking about summer plans (academic program, job, volunteer, science/art project?) • Create study plan for finals
December	• Begin applying to summer programs • Evaluate extracurricular involvement; any adjustments needed for next semester? • Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over break • Begin researching the best ways to study for the SAT or ACT • Draft goals for spring semester; timeline milestones • Brainstorm ideas for your independent project, if you choose to do one • Revise/update your resume

Sophomore Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• Take a diagnostic SAT or ACT and devise a study plan to take the exam next fall • Get your time-management plan down for a strong semester • Keep your extracurricular goals in mind; it's important to be active outside the classroom! • If you are taking an AP class or a class that matches an SAT II, devise a study plan
February	• Increase your extracurricular involvement in activities with leadership/collaboration in mind • Keep up with your volunteering or independent projects (like math or writing competitions) • Select your classes for junior year • Decide on a SAT/ACT prep plan and enroll so there's time before taking the real test in the fall • Complete summer program applications, if applying
March	• Keep up with your classes! Review time-management and goals! • Explore a few careers connected to your Skills-Interests Worksheet • Apply for summer volunteering, internship, or job opportunities • Start SAT/ACT prep plan and continue through summer; time is your friend!
April	• Visit a college or two during spring break (if you can't travel, visit a few local schools) • Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over spring break • Create time for extra study on subjects that need reinforcement in preparation for finals • Stay organized, cutting back on some activities if you are feeling overloaded
May	• Create a study plan for finals and reorganize time-management for maximum success • Finalize those summer plans! • Try for an officer position in a club for junior year; or make plans to advance the club you started • Revisit your goals, make adjustments, and stay focused to finish the semester strong

Sophomore/Junior Year - Summer

Month	Task

June	• Activate your interests through an academic program, volunteer opportunity, job • Continue progress on your independent project (iOS app? poetry blog?), if doing one • Keep up with assigned summer reading for junior year • Expand your mind through critical reading, viewing, or listening • Explore some careers through informational interviews, job shadowing, or web research • Visit a few colleges of interest; if you can't travel, visit virtually through web research • Research 5-10 colleges through web research or in a workshop • Save time for fun and relaxation! • Record your summer experiences in a journal; this might be handy for future applications! • Continue progressing with SAT/ACT prep, taking practice exams regularly • Revise/update your resume

Junior Year - Fall

Month	Task
August	• Take a really deep breath! Note to yourself that this is the year to do your absolute best :) • Check with your school counselor about college information sessions at your school • Define your goals, time-management, SM plan, and timeline for junior semester • Stay focused on your SAT/ACT prep; take SAT if signed up for August sitting • Think about which extracurriculars are working best. Try something new or increase involvement? • Assess how you're defining yourself outside of school; on the way to a unique college application? • Plan for competitions if this of interest to you
September	• If you are interested in a diagnostic score or applying for National Merit, take the PSAT • Keep up with your classes, noticing the increased demands and stress level of junior year • Get active in your chosen clubs or other extracurriculars • Keep it all together as the semester introduces new challenges; prioritize! • Take ACT if signed up for September sitting
October	• Pay attention to sleep and wellness as the semester kicks into full swing • Maintain good relations with your teachers; get to know them • Maintain extracurricular involvement • Start researching summer options that take things to the next level and showcase your talents • Take ACT or SAT if signed up for October sitting
November	• Get plenty of sleep (8-9 hours) so you can gear up for finals preparation • Maintain activities (or cut back temporarily if you need to keep your grades up); stick to priorities! • Begin mapping out some rough summer plans • Create study plan for finals • Take SAT if signed up for November sitting
December	• Begin applying to summer programs • Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over break • Draft goals for spring semester; timeline milestones

	• Take ACT or SAT if signed up for December sitting • Continue web research on colleges of interest; draft a list of 20 schools you're interested in • Continue career exploration • Revise/update your resume

Junior Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• Find ways to stay focused for the most important semester so far! • Define your goals, time-management, SM plan, and timeline for junior semester • Keep your extracurricular goals in mind; have you advanced in clubs and activities? • If you are taking an AP class or a class that matches an SAT II, devise a study plan • Retake the ACT/SAT a second time if necessary (applies to any month this semester) • Start exploring schools from the rough college list you made in December (do a few each month)
February	• Increase your extracurricular involvement your leadership/collaboration goals in mind • Keep up with your volunteering or independent projects (like math or writing competitions) • Select your classes for senior year • Explore a few more schools on your college list
March	• Complete summer program applications, if applying • Keep up with your classes! Review time-management and goals! • Apply for summer volunteering, internship, or job opportunities • Explore a few more schools on your school list • Talk to some of your favorite teachers about letters of recommendation for college applications
April	• Visit a college or two during spring break (if you can't travel, visit a few local schools) • Choose a few books, videos, podcasts for critical reading/mind expansion over spring break • Create time for extra study on subjects that need reinforcement in preparation for finals • Stay organized, cutting back on some activities if you are feeling overloaded • Explore a few more schools on your school list
May	• Create a study plan for finals and reorganize time-management for maximum success • Finalize those summer plans! • Try for an officer position in a club for junior year; or make plans to advance the club you started • Revisit your goals, make adjustments, and stay focused to finish the semester strong • Take AP exams • Take SAT subject tests

Junior/Senior Year - Summer

Month	Task
June	• FINALIZE YOUR COLLEGE LIST

	• Activate your interests in the strongest way possible this last summer before applying • Continue progress on your independent project, if doing one • Visit a few colleges of interest; if you can't travel, visit virtually through web research • Save time for fun and relaxation!
July	• START WRITING YOUR COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ESSAYS • Keep up with assigned summer reading for senior year • Continue with summer program or project started in June • Create an organizational plan for writing essays and completing all the applications on your list • Revise/update your resume

Senior Year - Fall

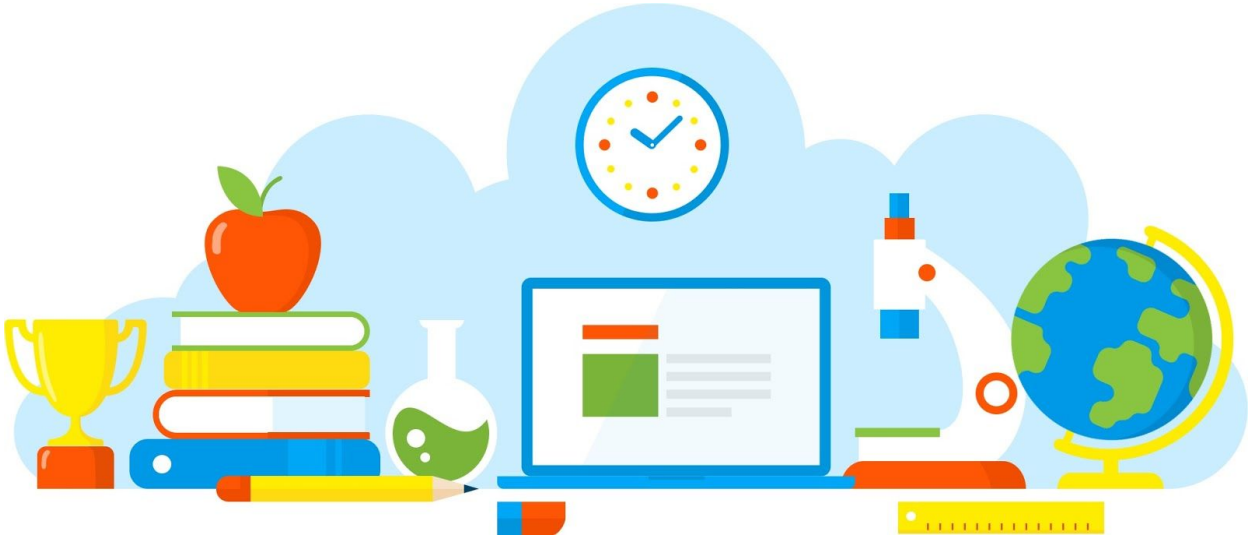
Month	Task
August	• Create a time-management plan that includes extra time for essay and application work • Think about what you can cut out to give you a little more time for multiple essay revisions • Check in with your teachers about letters of recommendation • Draft those essays • Any adjustments to your school list? If so, adjust your plan.
September	• Fill out your school's counselor questionnaire, if your school has one • Draft those essays • Keep up with classes • Sign up for admissions interviews, if applicable • Breathe
October	• Prepare for early admission deadline of November 1, if applicable • Fill out applications • Send standardized test score reports • Finalize essays • Complete activities list with descriptions • Include any additional information essays • Practice for interviews, if applicable
November	• If applying a state school with an 11/30 or 12/1 deadline, start finalizing essays • Fill out applications • Send standardized test score reports • Complete activities list with descriptions • Include any additional information essays • Practice for interviews, if applicable
December	• If applying regular decision with a 1/1 deadline, start finalizing essays • Fill out applications • Send standardized test score reports

	• Complete activities list with descriptions • Include any additional information essays • Practice for interviews, if applicable

Senior Year - Spring

Month	Task
January	• Hold a self-appreciation celebration! You have made it very far. • Also, keep up your energy! Some schools might be interested in your second semester transcript • If you're working on 2/1 deadlines, repeat steps above. • Practice for interviews, if applicable
February	• In the 1st half of the month, gather material, write, and send update letters to schools, if applicable • Enjoy a less stressful load, keeping up your time-management and achieving your goals
March	• Hold steady as you await results • If you are waitlisted at dreams schools, start drafting waitlist letter
April	• If you have some competing choices among your results, inform yourself about each school • If you can visit, do that • If you can talk to students or alum, also a good idea • Create a pro/con list for each school before making a final decision • If waitlisted, send waitlist letter
May	• On or before May 1, enroll in college! • If waitlisted, keep hope alive. Many of our students have been admitted later in summer

In Conclusion...



We believe every teen deserves a future rich in possibility. The key to that future is planning early and authentically, according to who you are.

It's you that schools are interested in – who you are as a person, not just your grades and test scores. In completing this workbook, **you've made an important first step**: setting foundations for your character, activities, and four-year high school plan.

Now it is time to execute the plan. As you do so, feel free to return to these sheets and use them as tools to adjust your system as you move along. Life will serve up all sorts of surprises you won't have expected. These tools can also help you get back on track as your situation shifts and changes.

For further guidance on staying calm and organized, check out the Extra Resources on the next page. We hope they provide further inspiration and information for you!

Extra Resources For You!

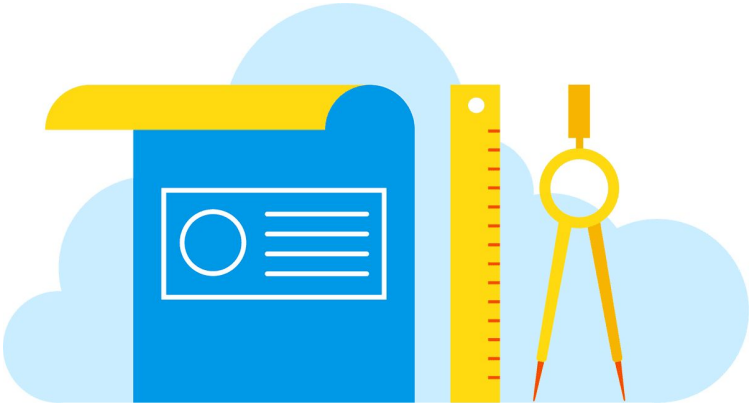
Our favorite mindfulness tools

Our favorite time-management tools and tips

Admissions Survival Kit Tool #4: Three Powerful Steps to Manage Time
Time Management for Right Brained People (Or What To Do If To-Do Lists Aren't Your Style)
A Simple, Effective Time Management System
Top Leaders Use This Scheduling Trick That Could Double Your Productivity
The Case for Using a Paper Planner

Resources for brainstorming jobs, community service and volunteering opportunities

Big Future - Career Exploration
Bureau of Labor Statistics
Career Girls
DoSomething.org
Hands On Bay Area
Idealist.org
Indeed.com
iSeek
The Muse
My Next Move - Interest Profiler
MyPlan.com
O-Net Online
VolunteerMatch



LinkedIn for Teens Applying to College - SmartSocial.com
29 Awesome Career Choices Most College Kids Would Never Think Of - Business Insider
5 Crazy Career Changes That Will Inspire You Not To Settle - Forbes
4 Innovative Women Engineers Tell Their Stories - UC Davis

Aptitude and interest exploration tools

The Big Five Personality Test
Johnson O'Connor Aptitude Test
Keirsey Assessment
MAPP Career Test
Myers-Briggs Self-Assessment
Rasmussen Aptitude Test

You Science

Articles about teen experiences

This is 18 - New York Times
18 New York Times Articles You Should Read Before You Turn 18 - New York Times
Many Ways to Be a Girl, but One Way to Be a Boy - New York Times
How Puberty Kills Girls' Confidence - The Atlantic
College Application Advice from 20 Girls in their 20s - Teen Vogue
Does it Matter Where You Go to College? - The Atlantic
Your Smartphone Reduces Your Brainpower, Even If It's Just Sitting There - The Atlantic
How to Keep Your College Admission Offer: Start With Digital Literacy - New York Times